

WSTR 109

STARDUST OTR RADIO

VISUAL RADIO STUDIO

USER'S GUIDE & USER MANUAL

Create immersive visual presentations from classic old-time radio.

“Close your eyes. Open your imagination.”



Prepared for WSTR 109 Stardust OTR Radio
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1. Welcome to WSTR 109 Visual Radio Studio

WSTR 109 Visual Radio Studio is a Windows desktop production application created for WSTR 109 Stardust OTR Radio. It turns an old-time radio MP3 episode into a Full HD visual-radio presentation using episode artwork, timed scene images, cinematic motion, transitions, an audio waveform visualizer, and station branding.

The program is designed around a simple principle: the audio drama remains the star. The images provide atmosphere and visual context without attempting to replace the listener's imagination.

This manual explains the complete production workflow, from loading an episode through rendering the finished 1920 × 1080 video.

2. What Visual Radio Is

Visual Radio is not intended to turn a classic radio drama into a conventional television program. Instead, a sequence of atmospheric images changes at selected moments while the original audio continues uninterrupted.

A typical episode might begin with episode artwork, move to a spacecraft leaving Earth, show the crew approaching Jupiter, reveal a mysterious pursuer, return to Earth, and end on a final scene. Each image can be timed to the story and given subtle cinematic motion.

The result is especially useful for YouTube presentations because viewers have something visually interesting to accompany the radio performance while the original storytelling remains intact.

3. System Requirements and FFmpeg

- Windows 10 or Windows 11.
- A working WSTR 109 Visual Radio Studio build.
- An MP3 episode file.
- Episode artwork and, when desired, additional scene images.
- Enough free disk space for the rendered Full HD video.
- FFmpeg rendering tools: ffmpeg.exe and ffprobe.exe.

FFmpeg Tools Folder

Visual Radio Studio uses FFmpeg to create the finished video. The application expects ffmpeg.exe and ffprobe.exe in the Tools folder located beside the exact running application executable, unless FFmpeg is already available through the Windows PATH.

If the program reports that FFmpeg cannot be found, confirm that you are placing the Tools folder beside the same WSTR Visual Radio Studio executable that you actually launched.

Without FFmpeg, the editor and preview may still open, but final video rendering is unavailable.

4. Understanding the Main Studio

The WSTR 109 interface is intentionally styled like a Golden Age radio control room, but the modern production controls are grouped into practical work areas.

- Episode Settings - series profile, MP3 episode, artwork, episode number, title, air date, visual style, accent color, and series logo.
- Visual Episode Preview - shows the current artwork, branding, episode information, and scene being previewed.
- Scene Timeline - controls the order and timing of the episode artwork and additional scenes.
- Audio Visualizer - controls waveform style, position, height, opacity, and appearance.
- Output / Encoder - selects Full HD output and the video encoder.
- Opening - enables or disables an optional Visual Radio opening sequence.
- Render controls - creates the final video and displays render progress, elapsed time, speed, and ETA.

5. Quick Start: Create Your First Visual Radio Episode

1. Start WSTR 109 Visual Radio Studio.
2. Select or create the appropriate Series Profile.
3. Browse to the MP3 episode.
4. Choose the Episode Artwork.
5. Enter the episode number, episode title, and original air date.
6. Select the visual style and accent color appropriate for the program.
7. Choose or confirm the series logo and WSTR 109 branding.
8. Open the Scene Timeline and add the additional scene images.
9. Use Auto Space Scenes for an initial timing layout.
10. Scrub through the episode and move individual scene start times to match the story.
11. Choose motion and image-size settings for each scene.
12. Configure the audio visualizer.
13. Preview important points in the episode.
14. Choose the output encoder.
15. Select the output folder.
16. Render the final 1920 × 1080 video.

6. Series Profiles

Series Profiles keep recurring information organized for programs such as CBS Radio Mystery Theater. A profile can be selected before loading an episode so the production starts with the correct series identity instead of rebuilding the same setup for every episode.

Use the Manage control beside Series Profile when you need to create or maintain profile information. Before rendering, always confirm that the selected profile matches the episode being produced.

7. Loading the Episode Audio

Use the MP3 Episode Browse control to select the radio episode. Once loaded, Visual Radio Studio can determine the episode duration and use it for timeline spacing, scrubbing, waveform display, and rendering.

Before building scenes, verify that the selected MP3 is the correct episode and that it plays for the expected duration. Scene timing is tied directly to this audio.

8. Episode Artwork and Artwork Fit

Episode Artwork is the primary visual for the episode and is always the first scene at 00:00 in the Scene Timeline.

Artwork Type

Artwork Type tells Visual Radio Studio how the selected image should be treated. For example, clean scene artwork can be used when the application will add episode information or branding itself.

Artwork Fit

Artwork Fit controls how the image fills the 16:9 video frame. A fill/crop option can remove unwanted bars by enlarging the image to cover the frame. Always use Preview to make sure important faces, titles, or objects have not been cropped.

For best results, prepare artwork in a 16:9 format such as 1920 × 1080 or another matching widescreen aspect ratio.

9. Episode Information and Branding

- Episode # - the program's episode number when one exists.
- Episode Title - the story title shown in the Visual Radio presentation.
- Air Date - the original broadcast date.
- Visual Style - helps organize the intended visual treatment, such as Science Fiction.
- Accent Color - controls the visual accent used by compatible interface/presentation elements.
- Series Logo - the logo or title identity used for the radio series.
- Branding - identifiesWSTR 109 Stardust OTR Radio in the presentation.

Use Refresh Preview after changing artwork, metadata, branding, or appearance settings so the central preview reflects the latest choices.

10. Building the Scene Timeline

The Scene Timeline is the heart of Visual Radio Studio. It determines which image is shown at each point in the episode.

Episode Artwork is locked conceptually as the opening scene at 00:00. Additional images are placed below it and assigned start times.

Timeline Controls

Control	Purpose
Add Images	Adds one or more scene images to the episode.
Remove	Removes the selected additional scene.
Move Up / Move Down	Changes scene order.
Auto Space Scenes	Distributes added scenes across the episode automatically.
Preview Selected	Shows the currently selected scene in the live preview.
Save Timeline	Saves the current scene arrangement and timing.
Load Timeline	Restores a previously saved timeline.
Use Timeline	Accepts the timeline and returns it to the main production view.

Auto Space Scenes

Auto Space Scenes is the fastest way to create a first draft. It distributes the additional scene images through the available episode duration. This is a starting point, not a substitute for listening to the story.

After auto-spacing, scrub through the episode and move scene changes so they occur at meaningful story moments.

11. Timeline Scrubbing and Precise Scene Placement

The Scene Timeline includes a scrub control that lets you move through the episode. The current position is shown as a time value, making it possible to listen or navigate to the exact point where a new visual should begin.

17. Select the scene you want to position.
18. Move the scrubber to the point in the episode where the scene should appear.
19. Use Set Scene Here.
20. Preview the scene and surrounding portion of the timeline.
21. Repeat until the visual changes follow the story naturally.

This is especially useful when a major event occurs in dialogue - for example, a spacecraft reaching Jupiter, a distress report arriving, or characters discovering that Earth has changed.

12. Scene Motion and Image Size

Each scene can have its own motion and Image Size % value. Subtle pan and zoom movement keeps a static illustration from feeling frozen on screen.

Slow Zoom In is one available cinematic treatment seen in current Visual Radio timelines. Motion should generally be restrained. The purpose is to add life to the scene, not distract from the performance.

Image Size % can be adjusted when an image needs slightly different framing. Always check the live preview after changing image size.

13. Audio Visualizer

The Audio Visualizer adds motion driven by the radio episode audio. It can be configured to complement the artwork without dominating it.

- Style - selects the waveform presentation, including Mirrored Waveform where available.
- Position - places the waveform in the presentation.
- Height - controls how much vertical space the waveform occupies.
- Opacity - controls how strongly the waveform appears over the scene.
- Accent appearance/color - coordinates the visualizer with the Visual Radio presentation.

A subtle visualizer usually works best for old-time radio. It reassures the viewer that the presentation is active while leaving the scene artwork and story easy to follow.

14. Opening Sequences

The Opening control allows an optional Visual Radio opening sequence to be used before the episode presentation. Select No opening sequence when you want the episode artwork and program audio to begin without an added Visual Radio introduction.

When an opening is enabled, preview the beginning carefully so the transition into the episode feels intentional.

15. Previewing the Presentation

Previewing is an essential part of the workflow. Use the Visual Episode Preview, Preview Selected, timeline scrubber, and Refresh Preview controls to inspect the presentation before committing to a full render.

- Check that episode information is correct.
- Check that artwork fills the frame properly.
- Check that scene order matches the story.
- Check that important scene changes happen at the right moment.
- Check that motion does not crop important content.
- Check that the waveform does not cover titles or faces.
- Check the opening and final scene.

16. Output, Encoder, and Rendering

Visual Radio Studio renders the finished presentation as Full HD 1920 × 1080 video suitable for platforms such as YouTube.

Encoder

CPU H.264 (libx264) is the dependable software-encoding option. Supported builds can also use compatible hardware encoders depending on the computer, graphics hardware, drivers, and FFmpeg configuration.

If an automatic or hardware encoder fails, try CPU H.264 (libx264). It may render more slowly, but it is often the most compatible choice.

Rendering the Video

22. Confirm the output folder.
23. Confirm 1920 × 1080 Full HD output.
24. Choose the encoder.
25. Review the timeline and preview one final time.
26. Click RENDER VIDEO / Create Video, depending on the build.
27. Allow the render to finish without closing the application.
28. Review the finished video before publishing.

During rendering, supported builds display percentage complete, current position, encoding speed, elapsed time, and estimated time remaining (ETA).

17. Saving and Loading Timelines

Use Save Timeline when you have invested time positioning scenes. This creates a reusable record of the scene arrangement so you do not have to rebuild the episode if you close the program or want to make later changes.

Use Load Timeline to restore the saved scene arrangement. After loading, confirm that the correct MP3 and artwork files are still available in their expected locations.

18. Recommended Visual Radio Workflow

29. Prepare the MP3, episode artwork, and scene images in one organized episode folder.
30. Name scene files in story order so they are easy to add and arrange.
31. Load the series profile and MP3 first.
32. Enter and verify all episode metadata.
33. Set the episode artwork.
34. Add all scene images to the timeline.
35. Use Auto Space Scenes.
36. Listen/scrub through the episode and refine scene start times.
37. Apply restrained motion and framing.
38. Configure the waveform visualizer.
39. Save the timeline.
40. Preview the opening, several middle transitions, and ending.
41. Render using the preferred encoder.

42. Watch the completed video before uploading.
43. Create the YouTube thumbnail and description using the same episode identity and WSTR 109 Visual Radio branding.

19. Troubleshooting

FFmpeg Required / FFMpeg Not Found

Place ffmpeg.exe and ffprobe.exe in a Tools folder beside the exact WSTR Visual Radio Studio executable being launched, or make FFMpeg available through Windows PATH. Restart the application after correcting the folder.

Export Failed

If FFMpeg does not complete successfully with an automatic or hardware encoder, select CPU - H.264 (libx264) and render again.

Preview Is Blank

Confirm that Episode Artwork has been selected and that the image file still exists. Then use Refresh Preview.

Scenes Are Changing at the Wrong Time

Open the Scene Timeline, scrub to the correct point, select the affected scene, and use Set Scene Here. Auto Space Scenes is only an initial layout.

Artwork Has Bars or Is Cropped Incorrectly

Review Artwork Fit and Image Size %. Use the live preview to decide whether the image should fill the frame or preserve more of the original composition.

Timeline Files No Longer Work as Expected

Verify that the MP3 and scene-image paths have not been moved or renamed. Because Visual Radio Studio is under active development, keep backups of important episode assets and saved timelines.

20. Publishing and Media Rights

WSTR 109 Visual Radio Studio is a creation and rendering tool. It does not grant rights to radio recordings, artwork, logos, photographs, music, or other imported media.

The person publishing a finished presentation is responsible for ensuring that the media used can legally be published or distributed. Program names and example material shown in the application may be used for organization or demonstration and do not imply ownership of third-party trademarks or content.

21. WSTR 109 Visual Radio Philosophy

Movies show you the world. Radio asks you to create it.

Visual Radio Studio was built to respect what makes old-time radio special. The artwork provides atmosphere. The audio provides the story. Your imagination does the rest.

THE GOLDEN AGE OF RADIO LIVES ON

Timeless Stories. Endless Adventures.

22. Quick Reference Checklist

- ☐ Correct Series Profile selected
- ☐ Correct MP3 episode loaded
- ☐ Episode Artwork selected
- ☐ Episode number, title, and air date verified
- ☐ Visual style and accent color set
- ☐ Series logo and WSTR 109 branding verified
- ☐ Scene images added in story order
- ☐ Scene timing refined after Auto Space
- ☐ Motion and image size checked
- ☐ Audio visualizer configured
- ☐ Timeline saved
- ☐ Output folder selected
- ☐ Encoder selected
- ☐ Full HD 1920 × 1080 confirmed
- ☐ Opening, middle transitions, and ending previewed
- ☐ Final video rendered and reviewed

About WSTR 109 Stardust OTR Radio

WSTR 109 Stardust OTR Radio is dedicated to preserving, presenting, and celebrating stories from the Golden Age of Radio for today's listeners.

Website: www.stardustotr.com

YouTube: www.youtube.com/@stardustotr